

Impact: High Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

The ask is the most important information in your message — burying it at the end makes the reader work to find it. Leading with the ask respects their time and dramatically increases the chance of a clear, fast response.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not rudeness — stating the ask first respects the reader's time; it is the buried ask that wastes it.
- Not context-free — the background still comes, it just comes second, sized to what the reader needs.
- It is putting the one sentence they must read where they cannot miss it: first.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Ten seconds into anything they send, you know exactly what they want from you.

Principle: Busy people triage by the first line — an ask they see instantly is an ask they can grant instantly.

What you gain

- Faster replies from the busiest people
- Fewer 'what do you need from me?' follow-ups
- Asks granted more often, because acting on them is easy
- Shorter messages — leading with the ask exposes the padding
- A reputation for being easy to work with

Why most people fail at it

- They feel the ask is rude without a run-up, so they bury it under politeness.
- They write the context first because that is the order they thought of it.
- The ask is too vague — 'any thoughts?' — so leading with it changes nothing.
- They bundle four asks into one message and get an answer to none.

CORE FORMULA

State what you need first -> Then context -> One ask at a time

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before your next request, identify exactly what you need and say that in the first sentence. Context can follow.

BEST FOR

- Making requests of busy people
- Emails and messages where the ask is buried
- Any situation where the other person needs to know your purpose before the background
- Reducing friction in professional communication

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. State — State what you need first

Open with the ask, specific enough to act on: what, from whom, by when. If the first sentence is not the request, keep editing.

Buried: 'So, some background on where the project is at...'

Stated: 'I need your approval on the vendor contract by Friday.'

2. Context — Then context, sized to the ask

Add only the background needed to grant the ask — usually two or three sentences. Label it as context so the reader knows it is supporting matter, not more asks.

Flood: 'To fully understand this, we need to go back to January...'

Sized: 'Context: the current contract lapses Monday, and legal has cleared the new terms.'

3. One ask — One ask at a time

Multiple asks compete, and the reader answers the easiest one. Send the most important ask alone; queue the rest separately.

Bundled: 'Also, while I have you, three other quick things...'

Single: 'That is my only ask today. I will send the smaller items separately next week.'

FIELD TIP

Write the email, then move the last sentence to the top.

Most people write their ask the way they thought it: context first, request last. The fix takes ten seconds — find the sentence with the actual ask in it and promote it to line one. If you cannot find that sentence, you were not ready to send the message.

Situation: You need a senior stakeholder to approve something this week.

Don't: 'Hope you are well! Just wanted to give you a bit of an update on the project first...'

Do: **'One ask: approve the revised budget by Thursday. Context in three bullets below.'**

PHRASE BANK

Lead With the Ask · Ask first, context after

- "I need your help with X — here is the context."
- "Quick ask before the background: can you...?"
- "I am going to lead with what I need: ..."
- "The ask is simple: ..."
- "Before I give you the background — I need X by Y."
- "I need a decision from you on X. Context below."
- "What I need from you: ..."
- "One ask: could you...?"

Context Follows · Adding background after the ask

- "The reason for the ask is..."
- "Here is why it matters: ..."
- "The context that explains the urgency: ..."
- "Background, if useful: ..."
- "For context only — not required to act: ..."

Ten-Second Asks · Short asks for busy moments

- "Thirty seconds: can you approve the invoice today?"
- "One thing: are you free Thursday at two?"
- "Quick one — can I borrow your dashboard slide?"
- "Yes-or-no question: should I send this tonight?"
- "Tiny ask: reply-all so the team sees your sign-off?"
- "Before you dash — can you introduce me to Sam this week?"

Structured Work Asks · Asks for emails and meetings

- "Decision needed by Friday: which vendor do we proceed with? Detail below."
- "This email has one ask: your sign-off on the budget line. Everything else is context."
- "I am bringing one request to this meeting: two days of design time next sprint."
- "Action for you, deadline Thursday: review section three. The rest of the document can wait."
- "To be explicit about what I need from this group: a decision on scope, today."

Warm Asks · Leading with the ask without losing warmth

- "I have a favour to ask, and I will just ask it: could you mentor Priya this quarter?"
- "I am asking straight out because I respect your time: can you speak at our offsite?"
- "This is an ask, not just a catch-up — I would love your help with my application."
- "You are the first person I thought of for this: would you review my draft?"

- "I will not bury this in small talk: I need a reference, and I would be honoured if it came from you."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Three paragraphs of background before the ask in the final line
Better: I am getting in touch because [background] — could you help with X?
Best: 'I need X by Y. Here is the context in two sentences.' Nothing more.
2. Weak: Vague ask: 'I was wondering if you might be able to...'
Better: Could you help me with X?
Best: Direct, specific ask in the first sentence. No softening needed.
3. Weak: Multiple bundled asks in one message
Better: I have a few things — can I run them by you?
Best: Most important ask first, clearly stated. Others in separate follow-ups.

DECISION TREE

If You are about to give a lot of context before making your ask

Flip it. Ask first. Context second.

"Let me start with what I need: ... Here is the context behind that."

If You are writing an email that starts with context

Move the ask to line one.

"I need X by Y. Background below."

If Your ask is ambiguous without context

Give a one-sentence ask, then one sentence of context.

"I need you to approve X — the reason it is urgent is Y."

If You have multiple asks

Make the most important ask first. Others can follow separately.

"The main ask is X. There are a couple of smaller ones if you have time — I will send separately."

SCENARIOS

Email to a senior person asking for their input

Ask first. Background second. — "I need your view on X before Thursday. Background: [one sentence]."

Meeting where you need someone to take action

State the action needed before explaining why. — "The action I need from you is X. Here is why it matters."

Favour from a colleague who is busy

Respect their time by being direct about what you need. — "Quick ask — I need X. Takes about ten minutes. Can you do it today?"

Negotiation where you have a specific ask

State what you want before making your case. — "What I am asking for is X. Let me give you the rationale."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: (three paragraphs of context) ...so anyway, if it's not too much trouble and you have time, could you maybe take a look at the proposal?

Colleague: (misses the ask entirely; does not respond)

With the technique

You: Quick ask: can you review section 3 of the proposal before Thursday? I've highlighted the parts that matter most.

Colleague: Yes — will do.

COMMON MISTAKES

The paragraph-four ask

Sounds like: '...so with all that in mind, I was wondering whether possibly...'

Better: 'Can you review section 3 by Thursday? Background below if you want it.'

The vague ask

Sounds like: 'Any thoughts on the attached?'

Better: 'Does the pricing on slide 4 work for the June launch — yes or no?'

The bundled ask

Sounds like: 'A few things: the budget, the hire, the offsite, and one more...'

Better: 'The one decision I need today is the budget. The rest can wait for Monday.'

Softening until the ask disappears

Sounds like: 'No worries at all if not, it is honestly fine, but maybe...'

Better: 'I would like your help with X. A no is fine — but I wanted to ask properly.'

Ask first, warmth never

Sounds like: (Every message a bare demand, no relationship maintained)

Better: 'Good to see you Friday. One ask before the context: ...' Warmth and clarity fit in the same message.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- Busy people respond faster to your messages.
- Fewer follow-ups asking 'what do you need from me?'
- Your asks are fulfilled more often and on time.
- You feel clearer about what you need before you communicate.

Signs to adjust

- Leading with the ask feels cold in relationship-sensitive contexts.
- The ask is too vague to act on without the context.
- You are making multiple asks at once.
- The context was actually needed before the ask and you removed it entirely.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When a request without context will be rejected before the person understands what they are agreeing to.
- In sensitive requests where the relationship needs warming before the ask lands.
- When the ask is secondary to sharing important information — not every message is primarily a request.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'Let me say plainly what I danced around: I need X by Y.'

- "I buried the ask in that message — here it is in one line."
- "Let me say plainly what I danced around: I need X by Y."
- "You have read three paragraphs and still do not know what I want. The ask is this."
- "I sent you four asks at once — ignore the rest, this is the one that matters."
- "That was too vague to act on. The specific version: can you approve the budget today?"
- "I realise I never actually asked. Asking now: will you do it?"

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Busy-executive chain

State the ask -> give the deadline -> context in two sentences -> offer the detail on request

I need your sign-off on the pricing change.

The deadline is Thursday, close of business.

Context: two competitors moved last week, and sales is fielding questions daily.

The full analysis is attached if you want it — the ask stands alone without it.

Favour chain

Name it as an ask -> make it specific -> size the effort -> make refusing easy

I have a favour to ask — I will just ask it.

Could you review my grant application before the 20th?

It is six pages; I would guess forty minutes.

If this is a bad month, say so — no explanation needed.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC003 — BLUF: Bottom Line Up Front

BLUF is the same principle applied to information; Lead With the Ask applies it to requests.

TC005 — Clean Request

Clean Request shapes what the ask itself should contain — this technique decides where it goes.

TC018 — Crisp Brevity

Crisp Brevity keeps the context that follows the ask from swallowing it.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Bury-the-ask audit

Review one message you sent today. Was the ask clear in the first sentence, or buried at the end?

Day 2 — Flip one email

Rewrite one email to lead with the ask in the first line.

Day 3 — Verbal asks

In one conversation, state what you need before giving any context.

Day 4 — Specific ask

Practice making asks that are specific enough to act on without asking a follow-up question.

Day 5 — One ask at a time

Send your requests as separate messages. Notice how much cleaner the interactions become.

Day 6 — Context calibration

Identify when context genuinely needs to come before the ask (rare) vs when it can follow.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did people respond faster and more accurately? Were any asks still unclear despite leading with them?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I state the ask in the first sentence?
- Was the ask specific enough to act on without a follow-up question?
- Did context follow the ask — not precede it?
- Did I make one ask at a time?
- Did I avoid burying the ask at the end?
- Was the ask clear to someone reading only the first line?
- Did I include only the context genuinely needed to act?